

ATCM 2360

DESIGN *(in)* HISTORY



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WELCOME AND INTRODUCTION



Greetings, and welcome to **ATCM 2360 Design Histories**, or as I'd prefer to call it, **Design (in) History**. My name is Norm Cox, and I'll be your instructor for this semester. I look forward to sharing some seminal examples of the influences of design throughout history, and its role in shaping and advancing civilizations, societies, products, experiences, solutions, and everyday life.

I would normally also look forward to interacting with you all and getting to know you in class. But regrettably, this semester's Design History class will be **fully online**, due in part to a perfect storm of AHT enrollment growth, lack of accommodations (facilities), faculty schedule challenges, and such. I apologize in advance, but we'll have a great semester despite the circumstances.

The recent past and post-pandemic-era semesters have been an unusual time for all of us, as we have had to adapt quickly to ever-changing circumstances and struggles in our personal, professional, and educational lives. As faculty at UT-D, we had to change the way we prepare and present our instruction. As students, you've had to adapt to learning either in isolation, in front of a computer screen, in "de-densified" classes, and often without the benefit of peer support, connection, and collaboration. And we've all felt somewhat unfulfilled by missing out on the rich social and educational benefits of full, in-person, face to face contact and interaction, both in and out of the classroom. But the silver lining is that we (faculty) have been given the opportunity develop a rich, narrative, self-paced form of instruction in our online courses.

So, don't be too concerned... we'll do our best to make the course interesting, insightful, though provoking, and enjoyable. Here are a few things you'll need to know to get ready to be successful in this course:

CLASS PROCESS

Each Sunday evening at midnight, beginning the week of August 24, I will post the week's lecture to the **Course homepage** within **eLearning**. The lectures will all be in PDF format, so everyone can view them easily, and download them if desired.

NOTE: *There will not be any synchronous/asynchronous video lectures, or Teams classes. The lectures will be 10-15 page written narratives that are easy to read at your convenience and are full of great information and insights.*

At the end of each of the uploaded lectures, you will have an assignment—a project, a reading assignment, a video to watch, a recommended activity, a request for lecture discussion, or simply an acknowledgement that you've read the lecture—that will be due the following Sunday night by midnight. This gives you a week to read the lecture and turn in the assignment. This is about as simple of a schedule as I can make it, so you should have no trouble staying on track and keeping up with lectures and assignments.

TURNING IN ASSIGNMENTS

Homework and assignments must be *emailed* to me by the due date. There will be 15 assignments, one for each week of the semester. Each assignment will be worth 7 points toward your final grade, for a possible total score of 105 points.

Each week's email will have a very specific **SUBJECT LINE** for the week's assignment. (For example, "DH Week 1", "DH Week 2", etc.). These specific subject lines will direct your email to a unique folder in my Outlook



mailbox for your class each week. Be sure to pay close attention to the subject line when composing your email so your assignment gets directed into the proper folder for credit.

FEEDBACK

I will occasionally respond with feedback or critiques of your assignments, though it is nearly impossible to respond to everyone, given the sheer number of student submissions per week. Please do not be concerned if you don't get responses from me. Let me assure you that I read every student's email and assignment, even if I don't comment or respond.

GRADING

Each Monday morning, I will review everyone's homework assignment, and determine a score for their work. Each assignment is worth 7 points, for a total of 105 points for the semester. I will evaluate your assignment based on the following criteria:

- (a) Was it turned in on time? (There will be a 1-point deduction for every day the assignment is late.) **DISCIPLINE**
- (b) Was the assignment completed, and exhibited a reasonable level of effort and thought? **THOROUGHNESS**
- (c) How did your work compare to the work of your peers? **EVALUATION**

Don't get too concerned with the criteria above. It is simply a guideline that I consider when recording your assignment grade. In most cases, if you turn your assignment in on time, show some degree of effort, and give me your best quality of work, you will likely receive the full 7 points credit.

I will NOT post weekly grades in eLearning, so don't bother looking. I simply do not have the time to do so. I will record your grade in my class spreadsheet each week and keep a running total. If you simply make sure you've turned in a quality assignment on time each week, you can rest assured that you're doing well in the class. I will give you every benefit possible to help you succeed. I will post a grade at midterm to help you gauge your progress to that point.

ANNOUNCEMENTS

Any announcements about the class, reminders, or notes will be sent to you via email through eLearning. (I've made the mistake of posting info on the **Announcements** page, but no one seems to get notified when this happens, so I've quit using it.)

YOUR RESPONSIBILITY

An online class, especially a lecture class, has its challenges. Our traditional in-person way of assessing a student's competency—attendance, class participation, exams, etc.—are all somewhat irrelevant for an online course. Since you won't be attending class, I can't determine your attendance or classroom participation. I also won't be able to know if you read the lectures, do the exercises, watch the videos, etc. I can only determine your participation and grade by your feedback, the depth of your thinking, quality of your homework submissions, and whether they meet the assigned deadlines.

Consequently, the value of this class to you is in your hands. I will do my part to provide you with information, projects, resources, and suggested exercises. But what you learn and take away from this class is purely up to you.

While this is described as an online class, it is not intended to be a one-way flow of information for you to consume. Hopefully it will be a trigger for you to think critically, deeply, and to spur your own curiosity to know more. As a result, I would like it to be an exchange of ideas and thoughts about the subject—a Socratic dialogue—so that we may both learn and expand our horizons. I encourage you to email your thoughts and feedback to me each week, and I'll do my best to respond and engage with you.

WHAT TO EXPECT

This will not be a prototypical history class that sequentially chronicles people, places, and dates. Rather, it will be a narrative look at how design helped shape civilizations, cultures, and societies. It will tell the story of design through seminal events that occurred throughout history, and by examining unique and interesting examples of design

innovations and applications. We will focus on how design has influenced the advancement of societies and human experiences throughout history in interesting ways, and how it can be a powerful force for crafting our future.



As pioneering computer science visionary, Alan Kay, one said, “The way to predict the future is to invent it!” Consequently, an understanding of the historical role of design is a precursor to understanding why it is a relevant skill, and how to apply it to future challenges.

HOW TO PREPARE FOR THIS CLASS

This is a history class, so we will be looking at examples of design from the past, as well as the people who pioneered the design discipline, and who were instrumental and influential in its development, advancement, and relevance for today’s modern challenges. As a student in the Bass School, and in design in general, you should be aware of and familiar with the people, products, and influences that that have shaped your chosen field of study. If you’re studying animation and games, for example, you should know the people who pioneered and influenced that discipline and be able to identify their contributions to the industry.

At some point during the semester, you will be asked about your mentors and historical influencers in your chosen field, as well as identifying some of the pioneers of the design industry. Now would be a good time to start researching some examples of influential designers, design exemplars, and the stories of those who changed the world or influenced culture through their designs.

HOW TO BE SUCCESSFUL IN THIS CLASS

As you know, in-class critiques of your projects and assignments are a big part of peer learning and assessments. They help you see how your work compares to others, and provides insights into how others analyze, understand and approach projects. However, while I would prefer that we have this sort of in-class interaction, our online mode limits

our ability to provide critiques and peer presentations. Whenever possible, I will post examples of your peers' work on eLearning so you can see how your work compares to theirs.

You'll be happy to hear that there will be no tests in this class, nor any lengthy papers to write. I do not find it necessary nor effective to have you memorize and recite dates, people, or facts back to me. Rather, I'm much more interested that you understand the concepts presented about the role of design in influencing the world around us. Consequently, your grade will reflect your grasp of the *concepts* through assignments at the end of each week's lecture.

I understand that online classes are not an optimal learning method, and that each of you may have challenges to deal with. I will be as accommodating and understanding as possible, but I also expect you to meet the requirements of the class.

I presume that you will have access to digital tools that you can use to create and express your assignments. Personally, for illustrations I use Adobe Illustrator and Photoshop. For presentations, I use PowerPoint, and for word processing, Microsoft Word. You are welcome to use any tools you are familiar with, but please do not send me any work that requires special tools on my end to view them.

Acceptable digital formats for projects and feedback (other than emails) will be Word docs or PDF docs. For graphic files, I prefer .jpeg, .png, and PDF images. I will also accept PowerPoint presentations.

IMPORTANT SIDE NOTE: I occasionally get opportunities to recommend a student (or students) for internships, projects, collaborations, conferences, etc. The only way I can get to know you and assess whether you would be a good candidate for a recommendation, is through the work you present during our class, your interest in the subject matter, and your feedback. Consequently, it is in your best interest to (a) engage in discussion and participation, and (b) present your best effort in the assignments, so I (and other faculty) know who you are. By making an engaging impression through your assignments, we can become aware of your potential and confidently recommend you for opportunities that might arise.

CLASS REFERENCES AND SUGGESTED READINGS

There are no textbooks assigned for this course. While I may refer to articles or books, I will usually quote or cite external work within the lecture. Personally, I wish there was a textbook we could all refer to, but alas...

CLUBS AND OPPORTUNITIES

As an additional bit of information, I'd like to make you aware of two school clubs that are very active in the design arena on campus.

UX CLUB: The UX Club (user experience) is one of the largest on campus and is generally centered within the Bass School. It is focused on the discipline of user



experiences—in software, products, services, interactions, etc. It offers opportunities to get involved in promoting design through experiences... in networking with peers and industry leaders... in attending workshops and conferences... in organizing conferences and events... and in taking advantage of opportunities to work with professionals in the field of design. (As a side note, I am also the faculty advisor for this club.) You can get more information about the club on their website at UXUTD.com

AIGA CLUB: The AIGA Club (American Institute of Graphic Arts) is the university



chapter of the professional organization whose mission is to “... advance design as a professional craft, strategic advantage, and vital cultural force”. The club is also centered in the Bass School, and focuses on visual design, graphic design, and communication design. It often collaborates with the UX Club, faculty, and industry leaders to offer portfolio reviews and critiques, networking events, design challenges, and such. It is very active on campus and takes a leading role in the promotion of the visual arts and design.

You can view UTD AIGA information at <https://www.instagram.com/aigautd/>

You can get more information for AIGA (professional) at <https://www.aiga.org/>

OTHER OPPORTUNITIES: One of the benefits to being a member of the clubs mentioned above is that they are often my go-to resource to find qualified students for internships, design challenges, industry projects, etc. When opportunities arise, generally I will send out inquiries to these club memberships to find interested students.



Additionally, UTD offices of development and corporate relations will often get requests for students to work on outside special projects. Again, students are usually found within the membership of these clubs.

Consequently, if you are at all interested in design, I would encourage you to join one of the clubs, both for the educational and leadership opportunities, as well as for the inside scoop on available jobs, internships, networking and learning opportunities, etc.

A PERSONAL NOTE

A few years ago, I discovered that I was the subject of a student's "Historical Figure" assignment in a "Theory and Research in HCI" class at Rensselaer Polytechnic Institute. (If you're interested, you can read her essay [here](#)). The student wrote about my influence in the beginning of her career. The essay was flattering, to be sure, but I wasn't mentally ready to cross the threshold and be considered a "historical figure" just yet in my career.

A couple of years later, I gave a lecture at Carnegie-Mellon University. After the lecture, a student approached me and asked to take a photo with me. Somewhat flattered, I obliged, and asked him why he wanted the photo. He replied that he had read about me and studied some of my work in one of his interaction design classes at CMU. He wanted a photo of himself with a "living pioneer" ... a well-intentioned, but somewhat sobering back-handed compliment.

While I appreciate the fact that I've had an impact on a small segment of the design industry during my career, I'm also reminded at how fast time and history moves and evolves. Apparently now I'm already a "living dinosaur" and "historical artifact". I guess you could say I'm the equivalent of a 1970's Buick that's still running! On the bright side,

in my 40+ years of design consulting, I've encountered many other "historical figures" and experienced an explosive evolution of the design science and creative practice. And while I am not a design historian, I have many stories to tell and will look forward to sharing many of them with you this semester.

OFFICE HOURS

I will look forward to getting to know you through this virtual class. However, if you would like to connect with me in person, please feel free to stop by my office on campus and introduce yourself. I will be on campus Tuesday-Thursday, but my available office hours will vary each day due to classes, meetings, etc. Casual drop-ins are welcome, or you may request a specific appointment for a reserved meeting time.

YOUR FIRST ASSIGNMENT

To confirm that you are enrolled our Design History class, **please send an email and introduce yourself to:**

Norm.cox@utdallas.edu with the following subject line: **DH Week 1**

Your email will confirm that you are enrolled in the class and establish a working connection for our future communication. This will also help me verify that your assignments will be directed to the proper folder in my Outlook inbox.

DUE DATE: Sunday, January 25, midnight.

AND FINALLY... ABOUT ME



I have been blessed with a very rich and rewarding career as a designer, consultant, innovator, mentor and teacher. It was not a planned career, but one that presented itself to me as opportunities along the way. I wanted to be an architect and design houses, so I went to Louisiana State University to study architecture but discovered a world of creative learning opportunities in design, art, journalism, engineering, psychology, typography, business, philosophy and more. My curiosity for learning broadened my interests far beyond just architecture, and I reveled in the joy of a diverse and seemingly incongruent education.

In the summer of 1972, a job offer fell into my lap as I visited family in Dallas, Texas. With my diverse education, I took a job with Xerox Corp. as a mechanical designer, then graphic designer and, finally, as a typography designer for their line of electronic typewriters. A couple of years later, as fate would have it, Xerox' Palo Alto Research Center (PARC) needed a visual designer to help imagine a new way of interacting with computers, called a graphical user interface (GUI). I joined the team at PARC, and helped pioneer the graphical interface, and many of the UI widgets and elements we still use today (e.g., icons, hamburger menu, drop-down menus, contextual cursors, scrollbars, scalable fonts, and dozens of other technological advancements developed at PARC, including laser printing, the mouse, bitmapped displays, etc.)

In 1982 I left Xerox, and started my own design consulting practice. For the next 38 years I was privileged to consult to dozens of international companies and apply my design skills across a diverse and challenging range of products, services and opportunities. Along the way I picked up 29 patents related to experience design (UX), and numerous industry awards for graphic design, visual communication, and illustration. I've juried international design competitions and have lectured all over the world to businesses, conferences and universities. I've been an expert witness in several high-profile patent infringement litigations related to design and have served on the boards of both educational and charitable organizations.

In my leisure time, I enjoy playing acoustic music (guitar, mandolin, dobro), fly fishing, designing stuff, and creating art (watercolor, found-object sculptures, calligraphy, etc.). I also enjoy writing, and published my first book of short stories entitled, *But Anyway, Dog Ate the Meat and Died* in 2020.

It is now my joy and pleasure to teach at UTD full time and be able to share with you some of the things I've learned along my design journey, including a few war stories from my years as a designer, consultant, and dusty road warrior. I hope you will enjoy our journey through design (in) history together.

Welcome to our class!

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read "Hume", followed by a long horizontal line.